24 ALKANES

The hydrocarbons separated from the fractional distillation of crude oil are mainly alkanes. This is the simplest family of hydrocarbons, containing only carbon–carbon and carbon–hydrogen single bonds. Here we look into the structures and chemical reactions of these compounds in more detail. It is assumed that you have already read Chapter 22 (Introduction to Organic Chemistry).

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Know the general formula for alkanes
- Explain why alkanes are classified as saturated hydrocarbons
- Understand how to draw the structural and displayed formulae for alkanes with up to five carbon atoms in the molecule and to name the unbranched-chain isomers
- Describe the reactions of alkanes with halogens in the presence of ultraviolet radiation, limited to mono-substitution



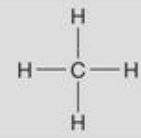
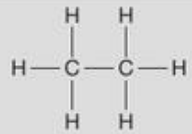
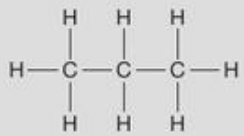
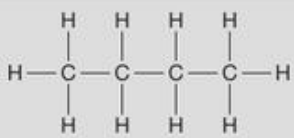
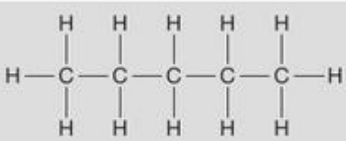
▲ Figure 24.1 The small alkanes are gases and are burned as fuels.

The alkanes are the simplest family of hydrocarbons. Hydrocarbons are compounds that contain carbon and hydrogen only.

Many of the alkanes are used as fuels. Methane is the major component of natural gas. Ethane and propane are also present in small quantities in natural gas, and are important constituents of liquefied petroleum gases (LPG) from crude oil distillation (discussed in Chapter 23).

The first five members of the alkanes series are shown in Table 24.1.

Table 24.1 Some alkanes

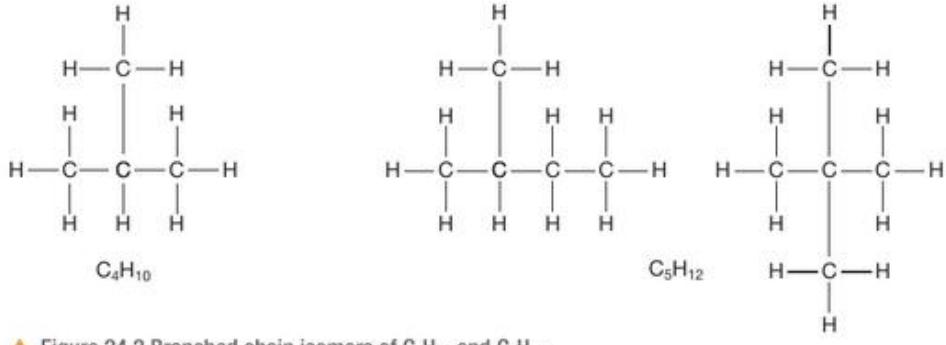
Name	Molecular formula	Structural formula	Displayed formula
methane	CH_4	CH_4	
ethane	C_2H_6	CH_3CH_3	
propane	C_3H_8	$CH_3CH_2CH_3$	
butane	C_4H_{10}	$CH_3CH_2CH_2CH_3$	
pentane	C_5H_{12}	$CH_3CH_2CH_2CH_2CH_3$	

KEY POINT

The alkanes are described as *saturated* hydrocarbons because they contain only C–C single bonds and have no double (C=C) or triple (C≡C) bonds. A way of thinking about this is that the alkanes are saturated with hydrogen, in other words they have the maximum number of hydrogen atoms possible for that number of carbon atoms. But do not write this definition down in the exam!

ISOMERS OF ALKANES

Isomers are *compounds which have the same molecular formula but different structural formulae*. The alkanes shown in Table 24.1 can all be described as *straight-chain alkanes* or as having an unbranched chain. There are also isomers of butane and pentane that have branched chains. These are shown in Figure 24.2.



▲ Figure 24.2 Branched chain isomers of C_4H_{10} and C_5H_{12}.

HOMOLOGOUS SERIES

HINT

When asked about a homologous series in the exam, it is probably best to only write about the properties (the second and third bullet points). Sometimes you do not get separate marks for 'the same functional group' and 'similar chemical properties', and perhaps a better way of writing this is 'they have similar chemical properties because they have the same functional group'.

The alkanes form a homologous series. A homologous series is a series of compounds that:

- have the same functional group
- *have similar chemical properties*
- *show a trend (gradation) in physical properties*
- can be described by the same general formula
- differ from the next by a $-CH_2-$ unit.

The alkanes form the simplest homologous series. The alkanes do not really have a functional group as they just contain single C–C and C–H bonds, which are the basis of all other organic compounds.

MEMBERS OF A HOMOLOGOUS SERIES HAVE THE SAME GENERAL FORMULA

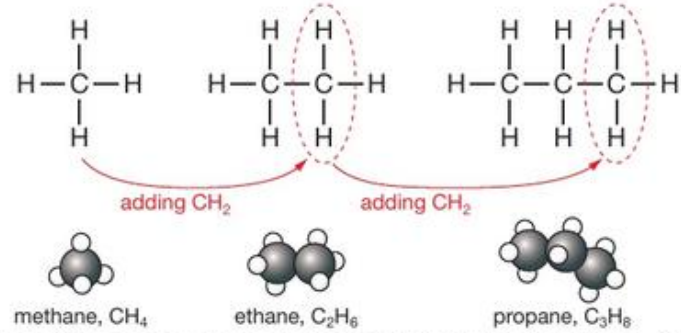
In the case of the alkanes, if there are n carbons, there are $2n + 2$ hydrogens.

The general formula for the alkanes is $\mathbf{C_nH_{2n+2}}$.

So, for example, if there are three carbons, there are $(2 \times 3) + 2 = 8$ hydrogens. The formula for propane is C_3H_8.

If you want the formula for an alkane with 15 carbons, you could work out that it is $C_{15}H_{32}$ and so on.

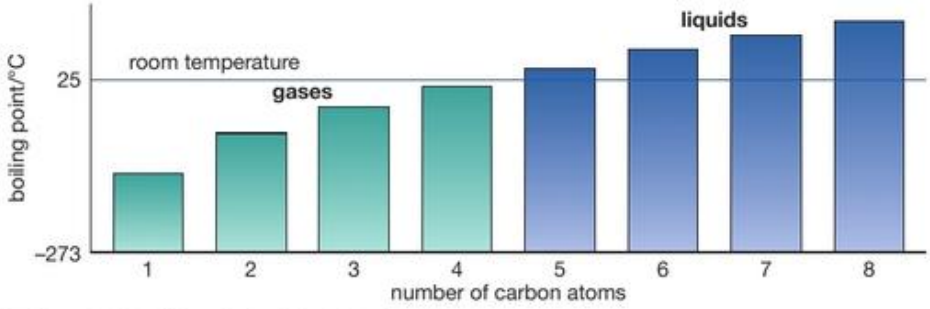
The reason that the alkanes and other homologous series can be described by a general formula is that each member differs from the next by a $-CH_2-$ unit.



▲ Figure 24.3 The three smallest alkanes. Each member differs from the next by a $-CH_2-$ unit.

MEMBERS OF A HOMOLOGOUS SERIES SHOW A TREND (GRADATION) IN PHYSICAL PROPERTIES

Figure 24.4 shows the boiling points of the first eight alkanes.



▲ Figure 24.4 Boiling points of the first eight alkanes

The first four alkanes are gases at room temperature (~25 °C). All the other alkanes you are likely to see at International GCSE are liquids. Solids start to appear at about $C_{18}H_{38}$.

The molecules of the members of a homologous series increase in size in a regular way and you can see that the *boiling points* also *increase* in a regular way.

As the molecules become bigger, the strength of the *intermolecular forces of attraction* between them *increases*. This means that *more energy* has to be put in to *break* the attractions between one molecule and its neighbours. One effect of this is that the boiling points increase in a regular way.

MEMBERS OF A HOMOLOGOUS SERIES HAVE SIMILAR CHEMICAL PROPERTIES

Chemical properties are dependent on the functional groups and bonding within the molecules. Because alkanes only contain carbon–carbon single bonds and carbon–hydrogen bonds, they are all going to behave in the same way. These are strong bonds, therefore alkanes are fairly unreactive organic compounds and are often thought of as being quite **inert**.

KEY POINT

The alkanes are not inert in the sense that they don't react with anything, like neon for example, but they are not very reactive for organic compounds and only really undergo two reactions.

TWO REACTIONS OF THE ALKANES

COMBUSTION

HINT

Don't try to learn these equations! Practise working them out for a wide range of different hydrocarbons. You will find guidance on how to work out the ethane equation in Chapter 5, page 41.

HINT

Remember, in combustion reactions it is highly unlikely that hydrogen, H_2, will be formed as a product because hydrogen is very flammable. You always obtain water, H_2O, even if there is insufficient oxygen.

All alkanes burn in air or oxygen. If there is enough oxygen, they burn *completely* to give *carbon dioxide* and *water*, for example:

$$CH_4(g) + 2O_2(g) \rightarrow CO_2(g) + 2H_2O(l)$$

$$2C_2H_6(g) + 7O_2(g) \rightarrow 4CO_2(g) + 6H_2O(l)$$

If there isn't enough oxygen, there is *incomplete* combustion of the hydrocarbon, and you obtain *carbon monoxide* or *carbon (**soot**)* instead of carbon dioxide, for example:

$$2C_2H_6(g) + 5O_2(g) \rightarrow 4CO(g) + 6H_2O(l)$$

or

$$2C_2H_6(g) + 3O_2(g) \rightarrow 4C(s) + 6H_2O(l)$$

SUBSTITUTION

Alkanes react with halogens in the presence of **ultraviolet radiation** (UV light), for example from sunlight. A hydrogen atom in the alkane is replaced by a halogen atom. This is known as a *substitution* reaction because *one atom has been replaced (or substituted) by a different one*.

EXTENSION WORK

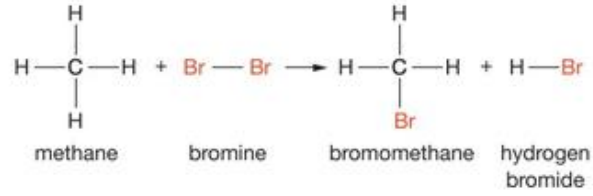
UV light is required for substitution reactions to split halogen molecules into atoms. Energy is needed to break the covalent bonds between halogen atoms. The atoms formed are called *free radicals* due to the presence of unpaired electrons on them. These are very reactive species which then go on to react with the usually unreactive alkanes.

A mixture of methane and bromine gas is orange because of the presence of the bromine. If it is exposed to sunlight, it loses its colour, and a mixture of bromomethane and hydrogen bromide gases is formed.

EXTENSION WORK

If bromine is in excess, this reaction can go on to substitute more of the hydrogens in the methane. What you obtain is a mixture of CH_3Br, CH_2Br_2, $CHBr_3$ and CBr_4, plus HBr of course. You will find out more about *multi-substitution* if you go on to do chemistry at a more advanced level.

$$CH_4(g) + Br_2(g) \rightarrow CH_3Br(g) + HBr(g)$$



▲ Figure 24.5 A substitution reaction between methane and bromine.

An exactly similar reaction happens between ethane and chlorine exposed to UV light. In this case, you get a mixture of chloroethane and hydrogen chloride gases:

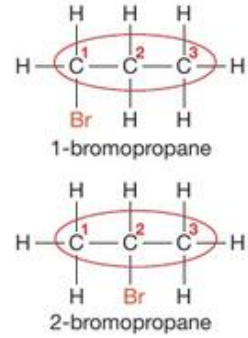
$$CH_3CH_3(g) + Cl_2(g) \rightarrow CH_3CH_2Cl(g) + HCl(g)$$

HINT

Notice the HCl(g) formed in this reaction is called hydrogen chloride rather than hydrochloric acid. To form an acid, hydrogen chloride gas must dissolve in water and dissociate to form H^+ ions (see Chapter 16).

Mono-substitution occurs when *only one hydrogen atom in the alkanes is replaced by a halogen atom*.

When propane reacts with bromine, it is possible to form two organic products even when only mono-substitution occurs. The two products are structural isomers of each other, they have the same molecular formula but different structural formulae.



▲ Figure 24.6 Two isomers of bromopropane, formed from the mono-substitution of propane with bromine.

The products formed from substitution reactions of alkanes with halogens are called *halogenoalkanes*. They are named according to the format *x-haloalkane*, where *x* indicates the position of the halogen atom in the longest carbon chain. So, when bromine reacts with propane we get 1-bromopropane and 2-bromopropane.